agenda retained influence within the organization, which contributed to debates about whether to remain obedient to Lashkar's official patrons or join the jihad against America and its allies.

It is useful to introduce several new characters at this stage, since following their stories through the ensuing chapters provides one means of charting these trends as they accelerated in the latter years of the decade. The first is Abdur Rehman Syed. He was a major in the Pakistan army, whose unit was stationed on the Pakistani side of the Durand Line in early 2002. Ordered to fight the Taliban fleeing across the border following the US counter-attack in Afghanistan he refused, and was subsequently demoted to the rank of captain. Although Syed was soon reinstated as a major, he quit the army that year and began working for Lashkar. Major Haroon Ashiq and his brother Captain Khurram, who served in the elite Special Services Group, also took early retirement. Both had met Zaki-ur Rehman Lakhvi and joined Lashkar after leaving the army. Abdur Rehman and Haroon became trainers, providing combat instruction to operatives and especially to those charged with executing fidayeen attacks. However, Haroon and his brother began distancing themselves from Lashkar in late 2003 as a result of the leadership's conservative and India-centric posture. They kept in contact with various members of the group, including Abdur Rehman, and attempted to influence their former colleagues—in one instance distributing pamphlets impugning Lakhvi. Although Abdur Rehman remained with the group until later in the decade, by the 2004–2005 time period he was developing differences with the senior leadership; leaving for extended periods of time to fight alongside the Taliban and beginning to leverage Lashkar's infrastructure to build his own networks at home and abroad.[35]

All three men became part of a wider network of current and former Lashkar members who challenged the leadership and, in some cases, the Pakistani state as well. They also all eventually gravitated toward Ilyas Kashmiri, who headed the Azad Kashmir chapter of HuJI at the time. He was detained in connection with the December 2003 attempts on Musharraf's life, but released several months later only to be detained again in 2005 after refusing to close down his operations in Indian-administered Kashmir. Upon his release, Kashmiri shifted his operations to FATA.[36] His outfit, known as the 313 Brigade, became responsible for a number of